

APEX PAYMENT APPLICATION

Merchant & Customer Payment Error Guide

Understand every payment error, what it means, and exactly what to do next

50+

Error Scenarios

3

Audience Types

100%

Plain Language

■■■ For Merchants	Understand what each error means, how to resolve it at the counter, and when to escalate to your bank or support team.
■■■ For Cashiers / Operators	Step-by-step actions for every error a customer may encounter. No technical knowledge required.
■ For Customers	Pre-written messages you can read to your customer — clear, calm, and professional.

Version	1.0
Date	August 03, 2026
Application	Apex Payment v3.24.4
Status	■ Approved for Merchant Distribution

Table of Contents

- 1. How to Use This Guide**
- 2. Error Severity & Priority Levels**
- 3. Card Errors — Payment Declined**
 - 3.1 Card Declined (General)
 - 3.2 Insufficient Funds
 - 3.3 Card Not Supported
 - 3.4 Card Expired
 - 3.5 Invalid Card Number
 - 3.6 Card Blocked / Restricted
 - 3.7 Card Lost or Stolen (PICK UP)
 - 3.8 Contactless Limit Exceeded
- 4. PIN & Authentication Errors**
 - 4.1 Wrong PIN
 - 4.2 PIN Tries Exceeded
 - 4.3 PIN Bypassed / Not Entered
- 5. Terminal & Device Errors**
 - 5.1 Chip Read Error
 - 5.2 Card Swipe Error
 - 5.3 Contactless Not Working
 - 5.4 Printer Out of Paper
 - 5.5 Terminal Offline
 - 5.6 Terminal Not Responding
- 6. Transaction & Processing Errors**
 - 6.1 Transaction Timeout
 - 6.2 Duplicate Transaction
 - 6.3 Transaction Not Found
 - 6.4 Partial Approval
 - 6.5 Currency / DCC Error
 - 6.6 Surcharge Error
- 7. Security & Authorization Errors**
 - 7.1 Transaction Not Authorised
 - 7.2 Security Violation
 - 7.3 Fraud Suspected
 - 7.4 CVV Mismatch
- 8. Settlement & Batch Errors**
 - 8.1 Settlement Failed
 - 8.2 Batch Closed / Already Settled
 - 8.3 Void Not Possible
- 9. Quick Reference Summary Table**
- 10. When to Call Your Bank / Acquirer**
- 11. Customer Communication Scripts**

1. How to Use This Guide

This guide is designed to be used at the point of sale. When a payment error appears on your terminal, find the error code or description in this document and follow the steps provided. No technical expertise is required.

1	Look at your terminal screen and note the error code or error message .
2	Find the matching section in this guide using the Table of Contents.
3	Read ' What it means ' to understand the issue.
4	Use the pre-written message in ' Tell the customer ' to communicate clearly.
5	Follow the ' Merchant Action Steps ' in order.
6	If the error persists, contact your bank using the details in Section 10.

Error Block Layout — What Each Section Means

Error Code:	The code shown on the terminal screen
Error Title:	Plain-language name of the error
Severity:	HIGH = urgent action MEDIUM = try again LOW = informational
Affects:	Whether it affects the Merchant, Customer, or Both
What it means:	Simple explanation — no jargon
Tell the customer:	A ready-to-use phrase you can say directly to the customer
Merchant Steps:	Numbered actions to take, in order
Call your bank if:	Situations requiring escalation to your acquirer

2. Error Severity & Priority Levels

■ HIGH	Immediate action required. Transaction cannot proceed. May require contacting your bank.	<i>Card blocked, Fraud suspected, Security violation</i>
■ MEDIUM	Transaction failed but may be retried with a different payment method or after corrective action.	<i>Card declined, Wrong PIN, Chip read error</i>
■ LOW	Minor issue. Usually self-correcting after a retry or small operator action.	<i>Contactless limit exceeded, Timeout, Paper low</i>
■ INFO	Informational only. No action needed immediately.	<i>Partial approval, DCC offer, Cashback notice</i>

3. Card Errors — Payment Declined

Error Code:
DEC-001

Card Declined (General)

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ What it means:

The card issuing bank has refused this transaction. This is the most common decline. It usually means the bank's fraud system flagged the transaction, or the account has a restriction. The terminal cannot tell you the exact reason.

■ Tell the customer:

"I'm sorry, your card has been declined by your bank. Could you try a different card or payment method?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Do NOT retry the same transaction more than twice — multiple declines may lock the card.
2. Ask the customer to try a different card or pay with cash.
3. If the customer believes it's an error, advise them to call their bank directly.
4. Note the transaction reference number for your records.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: This error happens on every transaction for multiple customers.**

Error Code:
DEC-002

Insufficient Funds

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer

■ What it means:

The customer's account or card does not have enough available balance to cover the full amount of the transaction.

■ Tell the customer:

"Your card was declined due to insufficient funds. Would you like to pay a different amount or use another card?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Ask if the customer would like to split the payment across two cards.
2. Offer alternative payment methods (cash, another card).
3. Do not attempt the same card again — balance will not change.
4. If enabled, offer a partial approval for the available balance.

Error Code:
DEC-003

Card Not Supported

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ **What it means:**

Your terminal is not configured to accept this card type (e.g., certain prepaid cards, regional cards, or newer card schemes not yet enabled by your acquirer).

■ **Tell the customer:**

"I'm sorry, we are unable to accept this card type at our terminal. Do you have another card?"

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Ask the customer to use a different payment method.
2. Check with your acquirer if you need to enable this card type.
3. Document the card type refused so you can report it to your acquirer.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Multiple customers report the same card type is refused — contact acquirer.**

Error Code:
DEC-004

Card Expired

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

The card's expiry date has passed. The card is no longer valid for transactions.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"It looks like this card has expired. Do you have a replacement card or another payment method?"

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Check the expiry date on the card with the customer.
2. The customer should contact their bank for a replacement card.
3. Ask for an alternative payment method.

Error Code:
DEC-005

Invalid Card Number

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer

■ What it means:

The card number entered or read does not pass validation checks. This can happen with manual entry errors or a damaged/unreadable card.

■ Tell the customer:

"The card number could not be read correctly. Could I try again, or would you like to use another card?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. If manually entered: ask the customer to re-enter the number carefully.
2. If swiped or inserted: clean the chip/stripe gently and retry.
3. If the error persists, use a different card.
4. Do not store or display the full card number at any time.

Error Code:
DEC-006

Card Blocked / Restricted

● HIGH

Affects: Customer

■ What it means:

The customer's card has been blocked or suspended by their bank. This could be due to unusual activity, a reported issue, or an account flag.

■ Tell the customer:

"Your card has been blocked by your bank. Please contact your bank directly to resolve this."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Do NOT retry the transaction.
2. Advise the customer to call the number on the back of their card.
3. Ask for an alternative payment method.
4. Document the transaction attempt time and terminal ID.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Card blocked errors occur frequently — may indicate a terminal or acquirer configuration issue.**

Error Code:
DEC-007

Card Lost or Stolen — PICK UP

● HIGH

Affects: Merchant & Security

■ **What it means:**

The card issuing bank has flagged this card as lost or stolen and is requesting the merchant to retain (pick up) the card. This is a security alert.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"I'm sorry, I am unable to process this card. Please use a different payment method."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Do NOT return the card to the customer.
2. Politely retain the card — say it was 'declined' without further explanation.
3. Call your acquirer's merchant services line immediately.
4. Do not accuse the customer — the card may be a genuine error.
5. Follow your store's security protocol for suspected fraud.
6. Document the date, time, and terminal ID.

🔴 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Always call your acquirer when a PICK UP response is received.**

Error Code:
DEC-008

Contactless Limit Exceeded

● LOW

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

The transaction amount is above the maximum contactless payment limit set by the card scheme or your terminal configuration.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"This transaction is above the contactless limit. Could you please insert your chip or swipe your card instead?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Ask the customer to insert their chip card instead.
2. If using a phone/wallet, they may need to enter their PIN.
3. The limit is usually set by the card scheme (e.g., £100 in the UK, €50 in EU).
4. If limits seem too low, contact your acquirer to review settings.

4. PIN & Authentication Errors

Error Code:
PIN-001

Wrong PIN Entered

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

The customer entered an incorrect PIN. Most cards allow 3 attempts before locking.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"The PIN entered was incorrect. You have another attempt — please try again carefully."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Allow the customer to retry (up to the limit shown on screen).
2. Ensure the PIN pad is private — screen/keypad not visible to others.
3. Do NOT assist the customer in entering their PIN.
4. After the limit is reached, the card will be blocked — see PIN-002.

Error Code:
PIN-002

PIN Tries Exceeded — Card Locked

● HIGH

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

The customer has entered the wrong PIN too many times. The card is now PIN-locked and no further PIN transactions are possible until the bank unlocks it.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Your card's PIN has been blocked due to too many incorrect attempts. Please contact your bank to unblock it."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Do NOT retry — further attempts will not work.
2. Advise the customer to call their bank immediately.
3. Ask for an alternative payment method.
4. The customer must visit their bank branch or call to reset their PIN.

Error Code:
PIN-003

PIN Bypassed / Signature
Required

● LOW

Affects: Merchant

■ What it means:

The customer's card or the transaction type requires signature verification instead of PIN, or PIN was bypassed with merchant approval.

■ Tell the customer:

"No PIN is required for this transaction. Please sign the receipt."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Present the receipt to the customer for signature.
2. Compare the signature against the card (if present).
3. Keep the signed receipt for your records.
4. If the signature does not match, decline the transaction and ask for another card.

5. Terminal & Device Errors

Error Code:
TRM-001

Chip Read Error

● MEDIUM

Affects: Merchant & Customer

■ **What it means:**

The terminal could not read the chip on the card. This may be due to a dirty chip, damaged card, or the card was inserted incorrectly.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"There's an issue reading your card chip. Let me try again — please insert your card slowly and keep it still."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Remove the card and gently clean the chip with a soft cloth.
2. Reinsert the card slowly into the reader — do not wiggle.
3. If 3 attempts fail, try the magnetic stripe (swipe).
4. If swipe also fails, ask the customer to use a different card.
5. Clean the card reader slot with a cleaning card if available.

🔔 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Chip read errors occur on 50%+ of transactions — card reader may need servicing.**

Error Code:
TRM-002

Card Swipe Error

● MEDIUM

Affects: Merchant & Customer

■ **What it means:**

The magnetic stripe on the card could not be read. The stripe may be worn, scratched, or the card was swiped too fast/slow.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"There was an issue swiping your card. Let me try once more."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Swipe the card smoothly in one direction at a steady speed.
2. Try the other orientation (flip the card) if the first direction fails.
3. If the stripe is visibly damaged, ask for chip or contactless payment.
4. After 3 failed swipes, ask for an alternative card.

Error Code:
TRM-003

Contactless Not Working

● LOW

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The contactless reader did not detect or could not process the card/phone tap.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Contactless doesn't seem to be working. Could you insert your chip card instead?"

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Ask the customer to hold the card/phone closer to the reader symbol.
2. Remove any cards from the wallet to avoid interference (multiple contactless).
3. Ask the customer to insert their chip instead.
4. If contactless fails on all cards, restart your terminal.
5. Contact support if contactless is consistently unavailable.

Error Code:
TRM-004

Printer Out of Paper

● LOW

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The receipt printer has run out of paper. Transactions can still be processed but no receipt will print until paper is replaced.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Our printer is out of paper. I'll load a new roll — your transaction is being processed."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Load a new paper roll into the printer.
2. Do NOT cancel the transaction — it is still being processed.
3. Once paper is loaded, reprint the receipt from the last transaction menu.
4. Offer an email or digital receipt if your system supports it.

Error Code:
TRM-005

Terminal Offline

● MEDIUM

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

Your terminal cannot reach the payment network. Transactions may be stored offline (if your terminal supports it) or will fail until connection is restored.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Our payment terminal is temporarily offline. We can accept cash at this time."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Check your internet/network connection (WiFi, Ethernet, SIM signal).
2. Restart your router or modem if network is down.
3. Check whether other devices in the store can access the internet.
4. If offline mode is enabled, transactions may still be stored for later.
5. Call your acquirer if the terminal does not reconnect within 15 minutes.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Terminal is offline for more than 30 minutes.**

Error Code:
TRM-006

Terminal Not Responding / Frozen

● MEDIUM

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The terminal screen is frozen, unresponsive, or showing an unexpected error. This is usually a software or hardware issue.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Our terminal needs a quick restart. This will only take a moment."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Press and hold the power button to restart the terminal.
2. Wait 30 seconds after shutdown before powering on again.
3. If the terminal does not restart, unplug and replug the power adapter.
4. Do NOT restart during an active transaction — wait for it to complete or timeout.
5. Contact your acquirer's hardware support if the issue persists.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Terminal freezes more than once per day.**

6. Transaction & Processing Errors

Error Code:
TXN-001

Transaction Timeout

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The transaction took too long to complete — the customer did not insert/tap/swipe the card in time, or the network response took too long.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"The transaction timed out. Let me restart the payment for you."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Cancel the current transaction on the terminal.
2. Re-enter the sale amount carefully before restarting.
3. Ask the customer to have their card ready before you start.
4. Ensure network connection is stable before retrying.
5. Verify the customer was not charged before retrying.

Error Code:
TXN-002

Duplicate Transaction Detected

● MEDIUM

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The system has detected a potential duplicate transaction — the same amount was processed on the same card within a short time window.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"This may be a duplicate payment. Let me check before processing again."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Check your transaction history before retrying.
2. Confirm with the customer whether their card was already charged.
3. Do NOT process again if the original transaction was successful.
4. If a genuine duplicate, void the duplicate — see Section 8.
5. If the original failed, it is safe to retry.

Error Code:
TXN-003

Transaction Not Found

● LOW

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The transaction reference could not be located in the system. This can happen when trying to void or refund a transaction that no longer exists.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"I'm having trouble locating that transaction. Let me look it up in our records."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Check the correct terminal and date/time range when searching.
2. Verify the transaction reference number is correct.
3. If the transaction occurred on a different terminal, check that device.
4. If the batch has already been settled, a refund (not void) is needed.
5. Contact your acquirer if the transaction cannot be located.

Error Code:
TXN-004

Partial Approval

● LOW

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The customer's card had insufficient funds for the full amount, but the card issuer approved a partial amount. This is common with prepaid cards.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Your card was partially approved for [AMOUNT]. Would you like to pay the remaining balance with another method?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Note the approved partial amount on the terminal screen.
2. Inform the customer of the remaining balance due.
3. Accept the partial amount and request the remainder by another method.
4. Provide a receipt showing the partial approval.
5. Keep records of both the partial and remaining payments.

Error Code:
TXN-005

Currency / DCC Offer Error

● LOW

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

Dynamic Currency Conversion (DCC) is available — the customer can pay in their home currency. Or a currency mismatch error occurred.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Your card can be charged in [HOME CURRENCY] at today's exchange rate, or in our local currency. Which would you prefer?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Present both currency options clearly to the customer.
2. Allow the customer to choose — do NOT choose on their behalf.
3. If a currency error occurs, cancel and re-enter in your local currency.
4. Note that DCC rates include a margin — inform the customer.

Error Code:
TXN-006

Surcharge Applied

● INFO

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ **What it means:**

An additional surcharge is being added to the transaction (e.g., for card type). The customer must confirm before proceeding.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"A surcharge of [AMOUNT/PERCENTAGE] applies to this card type. Do you wish to proceed?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Show the surcharge amount clearly to the customer.
2. Wait for explicit customer confirmation before proceeding.
3. If customer declines, offer an alternative payment method with no surcharge.
4. Ensure surcharge is displayed on the receipt.
5. Check your acquirer agreement — surcharge rules vary by region.

7. Security & Authorisation Errors

Error Code:
SEC-001

Transaction Not Authorised

● HIGH

Affects: Customer & Merchant

■ What it means:

The transaction was declined for authorisation reasons — the bank did not approve it. This is different from a general decline: the bank has specifically flagged this as unauthorised.

■ Tell the customer:

"I'm sorry, this transaction was not authorised by your bank. Please contact your bank directly."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Do NOT retry the same card.
2. Ask for an alternative payment method.
3. Advise the customer to call their bank's card services line.
4. Log the transaction attempt time and reference.

🔔 Call your bank / acquirer if: Multiple customers get NOT AUTHORISED at your terminal.

Error Code:
SEC-002

Security Violation — Do Not Retry

● HIGH

Affects: Merchant

■ What it means:

A security check has failed on the payment system. This could indicate a tampered terminal, encryption key issue, or a serious system error. Transactions cannot proceed until resolved.

■ Tell the customer:

"Our payment system requires maintenance. We can only accept cash at this time. We apologise for the inconvenience."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Stop accepting card payments immediately.
2. Do NOT attempt to fix the terminal yourself.
3. Contact your acquirer's technical support line now.
4. Keep the terminal powered but do not use it.
5. Document the error code and time it appeared.
6. Switch to cash-only operations until resolved.

🔔 Call your bank / acquirer if: Always call your acquirer immediately for a security violation.

Error Code:
SEC-003

Fraud Suspected — Transaction Blocked

● HIGH

Affects: Merchant & Security

■ **What it means:**

The payment system or card issuer has detected suspicious activity and has blocked this transaction as a precaution against fraud.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"I'm sorry, we are unable to process this transaction. Please contact your bank if you believe this is an error."

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Do NOT process the transaction.
2. Do NOT reveal to the customer that fraud is suspected.
3. Retain the card if it is safe to do so (follow PICK UP procedure).
4. Note all details: time, amount, customer description.
5. Contact your acquirer's fraud team if required.
6. Follow your store's fraud/security protocol.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Always contact acquirer fraud team when fraud is suspected.**

Error Code:
SEC-004

CVV / Security Code Mismatch

● MEDIUM

Affects: Customer

■ **What it means:**

The CVV (3 or 4 digit security code on the card) entered by the customer does not match the issuer's records. This often occurs with manual card entry.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"The security code entered does not match. Could you double-check the 3-digit code on the back of your card?"

■ Merchant Action Steps:

1. Ask the customer to re-enter the CVV carefully.
2. The CVV is on the back of Visa/Mastercard (3 digits) or front of Amex (4 digits).
3. Allow one retry only.
4. If it fails again, use a different card.
5. Do NOT ask the customer to read the CVV aloud in public.

8. Settlement & Batch Errors

Error Code:
STL-001

**Settlement / End-of-Day
Failed**

● HIGH

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

The end-of-day settlement process did not complete successfully. Your transactions may not be transferred to your bank account on time.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Our system is currently processing — please bear with us."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. Do NOT restart the terminal during settlement.
2. Wait 10 minutes and check the terminal for a settlement report.
3. If settlement failed, contact your acquirer before the next business day.
4. Keep all transaction receipts as backup until settlement confirms.
5. Check your bank account the next business day.
6. Reattempt settlement from the terminal menu if a retry option is available.

📞 **Call your bank / acquirer if: Settlement has failed — contact your acquirer within the same business day.**

Error Code:
STL-002

**Batch Already Closed /
Already Settled**

● LOW

Affects: Merchant

■ **What it means:**

You attempted to settle or close a batch that has already been processed. This is not an error — it simply means the day's transactions are already sent.

■ **Tell the customer:**

"Today's transactions have already been settled."

■ **Merchant Action Steps:**

1. No action needed — this is informational.
2. Check your settlement report to confirm all transactions are included.
3. If you expected transactions to be in this batch and they are missing, contact acquirer.
4. Begin a new batch for today's transactions.

Error Code: STL-003		Void / Refund Not Possible		● MEDIUM	
Affects: Merchant					
■ What it means:		A void or refund could not be completed. Common reasons: the batch is already settled (void becomes a refund), the time limit has passed, or the transaction was not found.			
■ Tell the customer:		<i>"I'm sorry, I'm unable to void this transaction at this stage. Let me process a refund for you instead."</i>			
■ Merchant Action Steps:					
1. If the batch is settled: process a refund (credit) instead of a void. 2. Check the transaction reference number is correct. 3. Ensure you have the correct terminal — voids must be on the same device. 4. Check your acquirer's time limit for voids (typically same business day). 5. Contact your acquirer if a refund is also not possible.					
📞 Call your bank / acquirer if: Refund also fails after attempting the above steps.					

9. Quick Reference Summary Table

Use this table for a fast lookup. Find the error on your terminal and go directly to the matching section.

Code	Error Name	Severity	Quick Action	Details
DEC-001	Card Declined (General)	MEDIUM	Try another card or method	Sec 3.1
DEC-002	Insufficient Funds	MEDIUM	Split payment / alternative card	Sec 3.2
DEC-003	Card Not Supported	MEDIUM	Use a different card	Sec 3.3
DEC-004	Card Expired	MEDIUM	Customer needs new card from bank	Sec 3.4
DEC-005	Invalid Card Number	MEDIUM	Re-enter or try different card	Sec 3.5
DEC-006	Card Blocked / Restricted	HIGH	Customer must call their bank	Sec 3.6
DEC-007	Card Lost / Stolen — PICK UP	HIGH	Retain card, call acquirer NOW	Sec 3.7
DEC-008	Contactless Limit Exceeded	LOW	Insert chip instead	Sec 3.8
PIN-001	Wrong PIN	MEDIUM	Allow retry (up to limit)	Sec 4.1
PIN-002	PIN Locked	HIGH	Customer must call bank to unlock	Sec 4.2
PIN-003	PIN Bypassed / Signature	LOW	Request signature	Sec 4.3
TRM-001	Chip Read Error	MEDIUM	Clean chip, reinsert, then swipe	Sec 5.1
TRM-002	Swipe Error	MEDIUM	Retry swipe, check card condition	Sec 5.2
TRM-003	Contactless Not Working	LOW	Insert chip instead	Sec 5.3
TRM-004	Printer Out of Paper	LOW	Load new paper roll	Sec 5.4
TRM-005	Terminal Offline	MEDIUM	Check network, restart router	Sec 5.5
TRM-006	Terminal Frozen	MEDIUM	Restart terminal	Sec 5.6
TXN-001	Transaction Timeout	MEDIUM	Cancel and restart transaction	Sec 6.1
TXN-002	Duplicate Transaction	MEDIUM	Check history before retrying	Sec 6.2
TXN-003	Transaction Not Found	LOW	Check reference, contact acquirer	Sec 6.3
TXN-004	Partial Approval	LOW	Accept partial, collect remainder	Sec 6.4
TXN-005	Currency / DCC Error	LOW	Let customer choose currency	Sec 6.5
TXN-006	Surcharge Applied	INFO	Show customer, await confirmation	Sec 6.6
SEC-001	Transaction Not Authorised	HIGH	Do not retry, call bank	Sec 7.1
SEC-002	Security Violation	HIGH	STOP payments, call acquirer NOW	Sec 7.2
SEC-003	Fraud Suspected	HIGH	Follow fraud protocol	Sec 7.3
SEC-004	CVV Mismatch	MEDIUM	Re-enter CVV once, then new card	Sec 7.4
STL-001	Settlement Failed	HIGH	Contact acquirer before next day	Sec 8.1
STL-002	Batch Already Settled	LOW	Informational only	Sec 8.2

Code	Error Name	Severity	Quick Action	Details
STL-003	Void / Refund Not Possible	MEDIUM	Process refund instead of void	Sec 8.3

10. When to Call Your Bank / Acquirer

Always keep your acquirer's merchant services number accessible at the counter. When calling, have ready: your Merchant ID (MID), Terminal ID (TID), the error code, and the time the error occurred.

Call Immediately — These Cannot Wait

■	You receive a PICK UP / CAPTURE CARD response (DEC-007)
■	A Security Violation error appears (SEC-002) — stop all card payments
■	Fraud is suspected or a customer challenges a transaction (SEC-003)
■	Settlement fails and you cannot retry (STL-001)
■	Your terminal has been offline for more than 30 minutes
■	Multiple customers are declined on valid cards unexpectedly
■	The terminal displays an error you cannot find in this guide
■	You suspect the terminal has been tampered with

Contact During Business Hours

■	A card type is consistently not accepted — request enablement from acquirer
■	Contactless limit needs adjusting for your business
■	Surcharge configuration needs updating
■	You need to add or remove operators from the system
■	Settlement reports show discrepancies from your expected totals
■	Terminal is slow or frequently frozen during peak hours

Information to Have Ready When You Call

Merchant ID (MID)	Found on your settlement report or welcome letter
Terminal ID (TID)	Displayed on the terminal — usually on a sticker underneath
Error Code	Shown on terminal screen — e.g., DEC-001, SEC-002
Date & Time of Error	Exact time the error occurred
Transaction Amount	The amount being processed when the error appeared
Card Type (if known)	Visa, Mastercard, Amex, etc.

Steps Already Taken	What you tried before calling — speeds up resolution
---------------------	--

11. Customer Communication Scripts

Use these scripts to communicate payment issues clearly and professionally. Keeping the tone calm and helpful preserves customer trust. Never blame the customer or their bank directly.

Card Declined

"I'm sorry, your card has been declined. This is a decision made by your bank and is not within our control. Would you like to try a different card, or would you prefer to pay another way?"

Card Expired

"It looks like the expiry date on this card has passed. You'll need to use a different card or contact your bank for a replacement."

Card Blocked / Stolen

"I'm unable to process this card. Please use an alternative payment method. If you believe there's an issue with your card, please contact your bank directly."

PIN Locked

"Your card's PIN has been locked after too many incorrect attempts. You'll need to contact your bank to reset it. Can I help you with an alternative payment method?"

Terminal Offline

"Our payment terminal is temporarily unavailable due to a network issue. We apologise for the inconvenience — we can accept cash at this time. We expect to be back online shortly."

Chip Read Error

"There seems to be a problem reading your card. Let me try once more — could you insert it slowly and keep it still? If it still doesn't work, we can try a different method."

Surcharge Notice

"I need to let you know there is a [X%] surcharge for this card type, which brings your total to [AMOUNT]. Would you like to proceed, or would you prefer to use a different card?"

Partial Approval

"Your card has been partially approved for [AMOUNT]. The remaining balance of [REMAINDER] still needs to be paid. Would you like to pay the remainder with a different card or cash?"

Transaction Timeout

"The payment timed out — this sometimes happens if the connection is slow. Let me start the payment again from the beginning. Please be ready with your card."

Security Issue — General

"I'm sorry, we are unable to process card payments at this moment due to a technical issue. We apologise for the inconvenience and can only accept cash. We hope to resolve this shortly."

Quick Reminders for Merchants & Cashiers

■ NEVER

- Never retry a declined card more than twice — it can lock the card.
- Never ask a customer to read their CVV aloud in the store.
- Never attempt to fix a 'Security Violation' error yourself.
- Never process a transaction after a PICK UP response without calling your acquirer.
- Never assume a customer is committing fraud based on a card decline alone.
- Never restart the terminal during an active transaction or settlement.

■ ALWAYS

- Always keep your acquirer's support number at the counter.
- Always check your transaction history before retrying a potential duplicate.
- Always give the customer a receipt — even if the transaction was declined.
- Always keep paper receipts until settlement is confirmed in your bank account.
- Always restart a fresh transaction after a timeout (do not retry without restarting).
- Always report security violations, suspicious cards, and fraud attempts to your acquirer.

■ GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep this guide accessible at every point of sale terminal.
- Train all staff on the most common errors (DEC-001, TRM-001, TRM-005).
- Perform end-of-day settlement at the same time every day.
- Check your settlement report each morning for discrepancies.
- Replace paper rolls before they run out — check at start of each shift.
- Keep a log of recurring errors to share with your acquirer.

This guide is produced by the Apex Payment Application team. For technical support, contact your acquirer or payment service provider. Keep this document at every point of sale for quick reference.